NO. 2
JANUARY 2027

GUIDED CHILDHOOD NEWS

AGES 6 TO 11
PRINT, READ, DO

The Guided Times

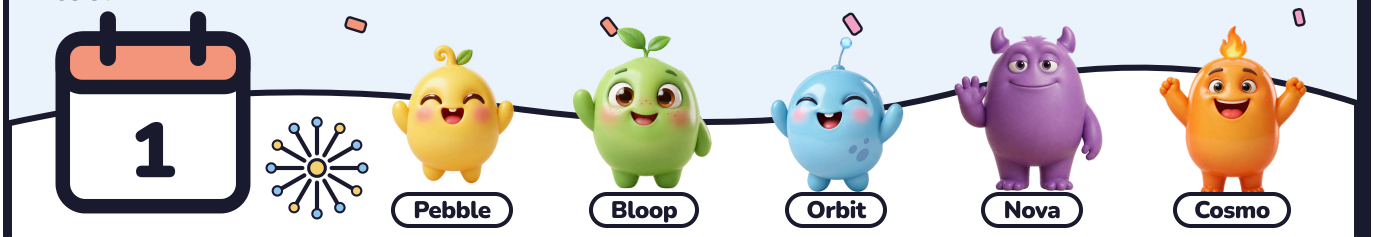
Happy news for growing up with screens

FRONT PAGE NEWS

New Year, New Deal!

Happy New Year!

The Planet Friends are writing screen deals with their families this month. Here is how yours can too.



A screen deal is a short list your whole family agrees: when screens are on, where they sleep, and what happens when time is up. No arguing every night, because the deal already says.

Turn to page 3 to write yours in six steps, then pin it up with the poster in the middle of this paper. Your grown up gets a star bit too.

IN THIS ISSUE

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Seven phone free dinners 4
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Puzzles and jokes 10

Wow!

WOW FACT

January is named after Janus, a Roman god with two faces: one looks back at the old year and one looks forward to the new.

A LETTER FROM THE EDITOR

Happy New Year, and welcome to Issue 2!



This month is all about fresh starts. The Planet Friends are writing screen deals with their families: short, fair lists that everyone agrees. Yours can too, with the poster in the middle of this paper.

There is a challenge to try, a big question to vote on, and puzzles and jokes at the back. The bits for grown ups are marked with a star.

Happy New Year, DiGi

News in brief

FROM AROUND THE PLANET



Pebble's family counts birds

Pebble's family spent one hour by the window counting garden birds. Pebble saw a robin and drew it for the fridge.



Bloop's tablet gets a parking spot

Bloop made a sign for the kitchen shelf where the tablet sleeps. Make your own sign on page 11.



Orbit's password rule

Orbit's grown up says a password is like a toothbrush: you never share it. Orbit agrees, and keeps it secret.



Cosmo tries phone free dinners

Cosmo parked a phone for a whole week of dinners. Cosmo says the best bit was the silly table talk. Try it on page 4.

? DID YOU KNOW?
The RSPB's Big Garden Birdwatch began in 1979. Every January, families count the birds they see in one hour.

? DID YOU KNOW?
The first website ever went online in 1991. You can still visit it today.

Tabby goes back to school

THE COMIC STRIP, PART 2 — TO BE CONTINUED



The big feature

Write your family's screen deal

A screen deal is a short list your whole family agrees. Write it together in the first week of January, then pin it up on the poster on page 7.

1 Look back at Christmas

What went well with screens, and what was tricky? Everyone says one of each.

2 Choose protected times

Times with no screens at all, for everyone. Meals and bedtime are good ones to start with.

3 Agree earned time

Which jobs earn stars, and how many minutes a star is worth in your house.

4 Pick where screens sleep

One spot in a shared room where every screen charges overnight.

5 Plan the stop

Decide together what happens when time is up, so it is never a surprise.

6 Sign it and pin it up

Everyone signs the poster on page 7. Check it again at half term.



Pick a calm evening
The first week of January

→



Talk it through
About twenty minutes

→



Write it on the poster
Page 7

→



Check it at half term
In February



★ FOR GROWN UPS

Keep it short, and use your child's words where you can. Ask what they think is fair before you say what you think. If a line is not working, change it together at half term, never in the middle of a row.

This month's challenge

ONE TICK FOR EVERY PHONE FREE DINNER

Seven phone free dinners

For one week, every phone and tablet sleeps in its spot while the family eats. Grown ups too! Write everyone's name, then tick each dinner you do.

NAME	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
.....	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
.....	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
.....	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
.....	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
.....	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
.....	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

The rule: phones stay parked from the first bite to the last plate cleared. A missed night is fine. Just carry on.

TABLE TALK 1
What was the best bit of your day, and the trickiest?

TABLE TALK 2
If you could have any job for one day, what would it be?

TABLE TALK 3
What should we do together this weekend?

★ ★ ★

THIS CERTIFICATE SAYS THAT

Phone Free Dinner Champions

had seven dinners with phones parked and talking on the table.

Our family ..... **Date** .....

The big question

READ BOTH SIDES, THEN VOTE

Should grown ups have screen rules too?

Families answer this one differently, and that is fine. Read both sides, then have a family vote.



SIDE ONE

Yes, rules for everyone

SAYS NOVA

- ★ If phones are parked at dinner, every phone should be parked.
- ★ Grown ups get busy on screens too.
- ★ It feels fair when the deal is the same for everyone.



SIDE TWO

No, grown ups are different

SAYS COSMO

- ★ Grown ups use phones for work, for paying for things and for keeping in touch.
- ★ Some calls really cannot wait.
- ★ Grown ups can be needed by family at any time.



What if the deal has one line for everyone, like phones parked at dinner, and a few lines just for kids?

ORBIT HAS A MIDDLE IDEA

Family vote

Everyone writes their name, then ticks one box.

Names					
Rules for everyone	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Some rules for everyone	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Rules just for kids	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

The line our whole family will keep

★ **Top tip: grown ups, try parking your phone first.**

The app desk FAMILY SETTINGS, MADE SIMPLE

Five settings to look at together

Most tablets, phones and consoles have a family settings page. Sit down with your grown up and look at these five together.

- Time limits
- Who can chat
- Buying inside apps
- Age limits on downloads
- Bedtime for the screen

Ask these while you look

1. Which settings are on already?
2. How long can I play each day?
3. Who can send me messages?
4. What happens if I tap buy?
5. When does the screen go to sleep?

Most social media apps say you must be 13 or older to have an account.

Check an app

App or game .....

Its age label .....

Chat with strangers? Yes No

Money inside it? Yes No

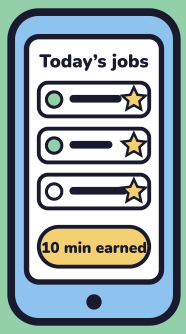
My grown up says Yes Not yet



Dear DiGi

"My tablet says time is up right in the middle of a level. It is not fair!" A question lots of children ask

That one is tricky. Before you start, agree with your grown up that you stop at the end of a level, not on the clock. Then the save point is the finish, and you know what comes next.



★ FOR GROWN UPS

Our app: Guided Childhood

Guided Childhood is the family app behind this newspaper. Your child gets their own app with no login: jobs earn stars, and stars become screen minutes. Every stage has short lessons on games, social media and AI, stamped in their Digital Passport. Grown ups get one small script for the evening's tricky moment.

guidedchildhood.com

PULL OUT AND PIN UP

POSTER 2 OF 12

Our New Year Screen Deal

Fill it in together, sign it, and pin it where everyone can see it.

PULL OUT POSTER

My time
Minutes just for me each day

Earned time
Jobs that earn stars

Protected time
No screens at all

Our screens sleep in the .....

When time is up, we .....

If something online feels wrong, I tell .....

We will check this deal on .....

SIGNED BY EVERYONE IN OUR HOUSE

....

....



A deal you all wrote is one you can all explain.



The homework helper

BACK TO SCHOOL AFTER THE HOLIDAYS

Back to school: plan the week



Write what is due each day and roughly how long it should take, then tick it when it is done.

HOMEWORK	MINUTES	DONE
Monday		☐
Tuesday		☐
Wednesday		☐
Thursday		☐
Friday		☐

Reading nights

Colour a square for every night you read. Five minutes counts.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
9	10	11	12	13	14		

Stuck? The help ladder

1. **Read it out loud**
2. **Look for an example**
3. **Try one small bit**
4. **Ask someone to listen**
5. **Write a note for your teacher**



★ FOR GROWN UPS

Homework and play can share a tablet, but not at the same time: close the games before the homework opens. And your school's own homework policy always wins.

The good sites guide

CHECKED BY ORBIT

New year, new hobby

Orbit has checked every one of these. They are free, and you can try each one without an account.



FOR CHILDREN

rspb.org.uk

Big Garden Birdwatch
Count the birds in your garden or park for one hour at the end of January.

wordsforlife.org.uk

Words for Life
Stories, rhymes and reading games from the National Literacy Trust.

scratch.mit.edu

Scratch
Make your own games and animations with blocks of code. Try it without an account.

bbc.co.uk/bitesize

BBC Bitesize
Help with every school subject, with short videos and games.

bbc.co.uk/newsround

Newsround
Real news from around the world, written for children.

Is it a good website?

- [ ] Who made it?
- [ ] Is it for my age?
- [ ] Does it ask for my name or photo?
- [ ] Did a grown up say yes?

★ FOR GROWN UPS

childnet.com

Childnet
Advice and conversation starters for talking with children about life online.

parentzone.org.uk

Parent Zone
Guides for parents on the apps and games children use.

internetmatters.org

Internet Matters
Step by step guides to the family settings on every device.

nspcc.org.uk

NSPCC
Online safety advice, and a helpline for any worried grown up.



Orbit's tip: when you find a good site, ask your grown up to save it, so you can find it again without searching.

Our family's new hobby



ORBIT'S NEW YEAR PUZZLES

Real or pretend?

Three messages arrived on New Year's Day. Circle real or pretend for each one.

1

FROM: GAME REWARDS
Get 1,000 free coins! Just type your password here.

Real / Pretend

2

FROM: GRANDAD
Happy New Year! Shall we count birds together this weekend?

Real / Pretend

3

FROM: ACCOUNT TEAM
Your account closes TODAY unless you tap this link now.

Real / Pretend

New year word search

F	Z	U	V	G	B	W	V	G	C
Y	G	O	A	L	S	H	X	D	B
E	R	F	B	J	D	C	Y	W	J
A	W	Y	I	H	P	M	C	K	Z
R	G	N	R	T	L	J	A	I	Z
J	S	R	D	I	A	F	L	N	B
Z	T	J	S	M	N	V	M	D	C
V	A	M	H	E	R	N	F	C	D
N	R	R	G	B	O	O	K	S	G
P	S	Y	F	D	E	A	L	J	D

- ☐ deal
- ☐ year
- ☐ goals
- ☐ birds
- ☐ stars
- ☐ books
- ☐ calm
- ☐ plan
- ☐ kind
- ☐ time

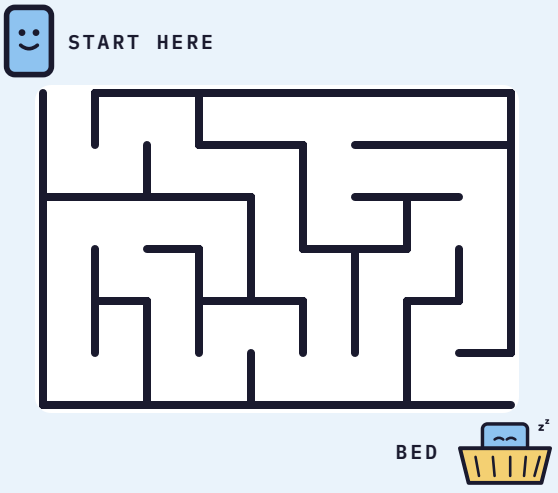
Crack the code

A is 1, B is 2, C is 3, all the way to Z is 26.
What should your family do this month?

☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
13	1	11	5	1

☐	☐	☐	☐
4	5	1	12

Help Tabby find its parking spot



Make and do SCREEN FREE FUN FOR WINTER WEEKENDS

Winter weekend bingo



Tick a square each time you do one. Four in a row and you choose the next family film!

Feed the birds ○	Build a blanket fort ○	Bake something ○	Play a card game ○
Write a story ○	Go puddle jumping ○	Make paper snowflakes ○	Help cook tea ○
Do a jigsaw ○	Read under a blanket ○	Draw a map of your street ○	Have a dance ○
Learn a magic trick ○	Call a grandparent ○	Tidy one drawer ○	Make up a game ○

Make a sign for the phone parking spot

1. Colour both sides.
2. Cut along the solid line.
3. Fold on the dotted line.
4. Stand it where phones sleep.

✂

Family time, back soon

FOLD

Phones parked



DIGI'S JOKE CORNER (ANSWERS UPSIDE DOWN)

Why did the computer go to the doctor? It had a virus!

Why did the phone wear glasses? It lost all its contacts!

Why did the robot go on holiday? To recharge its batteries!

The shop

SMALL ADS

Small ads from the Guided Childhood shop



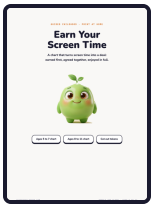
The Guided Childhood Passport

AGES 4 TO 16



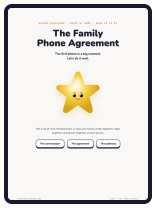
The Star Chart

AGES 4 AND UP



Earn Your Screen Time

AGES 5 TO 11



The Family Phone Agreement

AGES 10 TO 12



The Calm Down Corner Kit

AGES 4 TO 9



The Guided Times, Issue 1

BACK ISSUE

★ **etsy.com/shop/GuidedChildhood** Instant downloads, print at home.

COMING NEXT

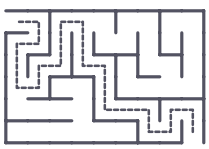
Issue 3, February 2027: the Safer Internet Day special. In our Etsy shop at the end of January. Tap the heart on our shop to hear first.

Issue 3



A free gift from us: the Guided Childhood Starter Pack, at guidedchildhood.com/etsy-bonus

If your family enjoyed this issue, a short review on Etsy helps other families find us. Thank you.





ORBIT'S ANSWERS

1 is pretend: nobody real ever needs your password.
2 is real: Grenada, with a lovely plan.
3 is pretend: a scary rush is a trick. Ask a grown up first.
The code says: make a deal. Write yours on the poster on page 7.